



The right choice:

Punjab Kings signed Shashank Singh at his base price of Rs 20 lakh during the 2024 IPL auction amidst curious circumstances, which the team has since clarified in multiple social media posts. PTI



Shashank in IPL 2024

MATCHES PLAYED

11

RUN SCORED

315

STRIKE RATE

165.79

50s/4s/6s

2/24/19

All stats updated till PBKS vs CSK match in Dharamsala

Shashank says.

Throughout the conversation, there is a wide grin on Shashank's face. Perhaps Jonny Bairstow should take credit for it. "I got a duck in our season opener (against Delhi Capitals on March 23), was sitting dejected in the dug-out, and suddenly Jonny tapped me from behind and said, 'If I don't see you smiling, I will stop speaking with you'. I have kept it in mind ever since."

Despite his accomplishments, no conversation with Shashank is complete without mentioning the IPL Auction in Dubai on December 19. After the franchise raised the paddle for him, there was confusion as another player with the same name, a younger hard-hitting batter from Punjab, seemed to be preferred. The franchise issued a clarification the next day, but Shashank wasn't fazed. Bangar called him 'around 6 a.m.' and assured him of the franchise's trust. "Hitesh Goswami sir, our Chhattisgarh head coach and talent scout for the franchise, indicated that Punjab Kings was interested in me," he recalls. "It's been reduced to nothing but a joke in our camp ever since." Shashank even appeared in a social media video for the franchise, humorously addressing the identity confusion with a famous dialogue from the Hindi film *Andaz Apna Apna*.

With his confidence being sky-high and form at its peak, call him old or call him a find. Shashank Singh, at 32, does not mind!